

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 63

Culture (OWC): [Khoi \(FX13\)](#)

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Sub Region: Southern Africa

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Place Coverage: South Africa

Section Title(S): Patrilineality • The Status Of Women

Mrs Hoernlé writing specifically on the behaviour between a brother and a sister says:

As tiny children they ran about together, but once they were grown up, they had to avoid one another completely. A brother was not allowed to speak to a sister directly, he must never be alone with her in the hut, he must never speak of her except in the most respectful terms. A sister was *tàras*, that is, a person to be respected, not to be spoken to or of lightly. In the old days an oath by a sister was one of the greatest oaths a man could take, and a sister could generally be relied on to stop any fight in which her brother was taking part. The brother is said to be shy (*sou*) in the presence of his sister, and the same is true of all the men a woman would call brother. Should one of these men use bad language in her presence a woman could demand a sheep from him with which to purify herself of the pollution. It is a *gei! Keis*, a great offence. Even at the present day a man will not sleep in his sister's hut when he visits her as a married woman. The eldest sister of a man is his *Gei Tàras*, his great respected one (Hoernlé 1925: 22).

[576
Etiquette](#)[593
Family Relationships](#)[688
Religious Offenses](#)[861
Techniques Of
Socialization](#)

It is interesting to note, in this regard, that the term *gei tàras* is also applied to father's sister as an alternative form to *eis geis* (big mother). Mother's brother, on the other hand, was often addressed as *//Náob*, a joking term, but also the usual term for grandfather (Hoernlé 1925: 19–22).

[576
Etiquette](#)[593
Family Relationships](#)[601
Kinship Terminology](#)

At this point in the argument let us merely observe that in the arena of the domestic economy a man stood in a special relationship not only to his wife but also to his sisters, especially the eldest, a relationship which demanded respect and to a certain extent deference. Both sets of relationships indicate areas of conflict, which I suggest have their roots in competition over property or control of resources: wives not only controlled the milk supply but also brought property (e.g. cattle and household utensils) into the marriage, while sisters inherited property in completion with their brothers — an eldest sister possibly inheriting more than her brother from her father, if we are to follow the rule Mrs Hoernlé got from her informant.

428
Inheritance

576
Etiquette

593
Family Relationships

Another area that dramatically reflects the relative status of men and women is the elevated position women seem to have occupied in legal proceedings. Hahn giving evidence to the Government Commission on Native Laws and Customs in 1881 says: 'The Hottentots avoid, if possible, to draw a woman as evidence before the court; the reason for this is the respect they have for a woman' (Cape Government 1883: Appendix C, p. 250).

562
Gender Status

576
Etiquette

Patrilineality

All accounts of the Nama emphasize the importance of patrilineality, but nowhere is this emphasis seen to be so strong as in Radcliffe-Brown's paper on the mother's brother, in which he states:

... The BaThonga, the Nama, and the Tongans, have patrilineal or patriarchal (sic) institutions; that is the children belong to the social group of the father, not to that of the mother; and property is inherited in the male line, passing normally from a father to his son (Radcliffe-Brown 1924: 17).

121
Theoretical Orientation

428
Inheritance

64 Radcliffe-Brown does not mention the existence of uxorilocality among the Nama because this would have weakened the use of the Nama material which he so desperately needed at the time to support his theory.

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